Nagarkot. Every time such a rumour reached the court Akbar, painfully hopeful, sent men to have it investigated. ‘The world is like a mirage,’ Akbar wrote to Abdur Rahim sadly, ‘to beguile thirsty souls… at the end of this frenzy is simply a mist—a fume.’

A Hindi couplet has been popularly attributed to Akbar, describing his state of mind:

> Deen dekhi sab din, ek na dinho dusah dukh
> So ab ham kan din, kachhahun nahin rakhio Birbal
> (He saw the poor and gave them all, but never distributed sorrows
> Now that he has given even [sorrow] to me, Birbal has kept nothing
> for himself)

Something had broken inside the Padshah, and he would never again contemplate returning to Fatehpur Sikri, because ‘the pleasant palaces of that city did not engage his heart’, wrote Abu’l Fazl. Akbar kept moving further and further north, to Kabul and then to Kashmir. Perhaps the palaces and courtyards of his erstwhile capital were too painful a reminder of a friend and courtier whose presence and companionship had made bearable the heavy melancholy that sometimes weighed on Akbar’s soul. The only Hindu who was so wholly devoted to the Padshah that he staked his most precious possession on the Padshah’s ‘religion’, his own immortal soul. So Fatehpur Sikri remained, not abandoned, but bereft. But for the next decade, as Fatehpur Sikri retracted back into itself, Akbar would discover Paradise on Earth.

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*This was the ruler of Badakhshan and Balkh, not to be confused with Abdullah Khan Uzbek, who earlier served in the Mughal army and then rebelled.